

THE FIRST-YEAR HOME MAINTENANCE PLAYBOOK

Everything your first home needs. Nothing it doesn't.

For first-time homeowners who inherited a property and suddenly realized they have no idea what to do next.

PAGE 1: INTRODUCTION

You bought the house. The closing was exciting. The keys are in your hand.

Then you walked in and thought: now what?

The previous owner never told you when the furnace was last serviced. The gutters are full of someone else's leaves. The water heater is older than your car. And somewhere in the walls, there's a pipe that's quietly decided today is the day to start leaking.

Welcome to homeownership. There's no handbook. Until now.

What This Guide Is

This is not a 200-item checklist that makes you feel like you're failing. This is a prioritized system built around one truth: most home maintenance disasters are preventable, and they almost always start with the same handful of tasks being ignored.

This guide gives you:

- A **seasonal priority system** — what to focus on each quarter so nothing critical slips
- A **cost-context decision tree** — so you stop second-guessing every repair decision
- A **tracking system** — so you never wonder "did I do this last year?"

Everything here is specific. No vague advice. No "talk to a professional" without telling you what that costs. No "coming soon" or "expand in V2."

What to Expect

This guide is 10 pages. Read it once, then keep the checklist page bookmarked. Come back to it every season. That's it.

If you're in your first year of homeownership, start with the Seasonal Priority System. If something just broke and you don't know if it's a \$50 fix or a \$5,000 emergency, go to the Cost-Context Decision Tree. If you want to stop reinventing the wheel every spring, set up the Tracking System.

Let's go.

PAGE 2: THE SEASONAL PRIORITY SYSTEM

Most home maintenance fails because people try to do everything at once. The fix is a seasonal focus system. Four times a year, you spend an hour on your home's most critical systems. The rest of the time, you handle what's in front of you.

Spring (March – May)

Spring is your home's reset button. After winter, things break. Find them before they find you.

HVAC tune-up: Call an HVAC contractor for a spring check. They'll inspect the AC side before you need it in June. Cost: \$100-200 for a professional tune-up. Skip it and you risk a July AC failure at 3x the price.

Roof inspection: Walk around your house (or use binoculars) and look at the roof. Missing shingles, sagging areas, or dark patches mean water got in. If you see problems, get a roofer out before rainy season. Cost: free to walk around; \$300-800 for professional inspection.

Gutter deep clean: Remove all debris from gutters and downspouts. Clogged gutters cause roof leaks, foundation damage, and basement flooding — usually in that order. Cost: \$150-300 if you hire it out. Free if you do it yourself with a ladder and a bucket.

Dryer vent cleaning: Pull the dryer out, disconnect the vent, and clean the lint trap and the vent line. Lint buildup causes house fires — it's one of the most preventable causes of home fires in the U.S. Cost: \$100-200 pro / free DIY.

Window and door seal check: Walk around each room and feel for drafts. Reseal with caulk or weatherstripping as needed. Cost: \$5-15 per tube of caulk.

Summer (June – August)

Summer is about the systems that work hardest when you do: the ones that make living inside tolerable.

Exterior trim and siding check: Look for rot, peeling paint, or gaps where pests could enter. Catching exterior problems in summer means you can paint or patch in dry weather. Cost: \$50-200 in materials for minor repairs.

Irrigation system audit: If you have a sprinkler system, run each zone and watch for broken heads, soggy areas (signs of underground leaks), and overspray onto the house. Adjust heads before you get a water bill that makes your eyes water.

Septic or sewer scope: If your home has a septic system or you're on municipal sewer and the house is over 20 years old, get a camera scope done. Tree roots and pipe degradation are easier to fix before they cause a backup. Cost: \$150-400 for a sewer scope.

Garage door hardware: Check the springs, cables, and rollers. Lubricate moving parts with silicone spray. A failing garage door spring is a safety hazard. Cost: \$15-30 for lubricant; \$150-400 if a spring needs replacement.

Fall (September – November)

Fall is your most important season. What you do in fall determines whether winter breaks your home or leaves it alone.

Gutter cleanup (again): October/November gutter cleaning is the one that matters most. Leaves fall, gutters clog, ice forms, water backs up under shingles, and you get a ceiling stain in January. Cost: same as spring — \$150-300 pro or free DIY.

Furnace priming: Call an HVAC contractor for a fall furnace inspection before you need heat. They'll check the heat exchanger (carbon monoxide risk), test safety controls, and make sure the system is running efficiently. Cost: \$100-200 pro inspection.

Weatherstripping and caulking: Walk the exterior and re-seal any gaps around windows, doors, sill plates, and utility penetrations. This is the cheapest thing on this list and one of the highest-ROI maintenance tasks. Cost: \$5-15 per tube of caulk; \$20-40 for weatherstripping kits.

Pipe winterization: Disconnect and drain outdoor hoses, close the shut-off valves to outdoor faucets, and blow out irrigation lines if you have them. Frozen pipes burst and can cause \$5,000-30,000 in water damage. Cost: free labor, 20 minutes.

Smoke and CO detector test: Press the test button on every smoke and carbon monoxide detector. Replace batteries. Replace units over 10 years old. This takes 10 minutes and saves lives. Cost: \$10-20 per battery; \$20-50 per detector.

Winter (December – February)

Winter is mostly about responding to what fall set in motion. But there are a few specific tasks:

Furnace filter changes: If you have a forced-air furnace, check the filter monthly in heating season. A clogged filter reduces efficiency and can cause premature system failure. Cost: \$20-50 per filter, depending on size.

Frozen pipe prevention: Know where your main water shut-off is. If a pipe freezes or bursts, you need to turn the water off fast. Also, keep cabinet doors under sinks open on very cold nights to let warm air reach the pipes.

Ice dam monitoring: After heavy snow, check for ice dams along roof edges — thick ridges of ice that prevent melting snow from draining. They cause leaks into attics and ceilings. Cost to prevent: \$200-500 for heat cables on problem roofs. Cost to ignore: ceiling repair, \$1,000+.

Water heater flush: Once a year, drain and flush your water heater to remove sediment buildup. Sediment reduces efficiency and shortens the unit's life. Cost: free DIY (garden hose into a floor drain); \$100-150 for a plumber to do it.

PAGE 3: THE 5 TASKS THAT NEVER WAIT

Some maintenance doesn't follow a season. These five things are urgent regardless of the month.

1. Know your main water shut-off location. If a pipe bursts, every second counts. Find your main shut-off valve today, make sure it works, and make sure everyone in the house knows where it is. Cost: free. Consequence of not knowing: thousands in water damage.

2. Test your smoke detectors monthly. Press the test button. If it doesn't chirp, replace the battery or the unit. This takes 2 minutes and is the single most effective fire safety action you can take.

3. Locate your electrical panel and label every circuit. When something trips, you need to be able to find it fast. Labeling now prevents panic later. Cost: free, 20 minutes.

4. Find your sewer cleanout. This is a vertical pipe with a cap, usually near the foundation or in the yard. It's your access point if a sewer backup happens. Knowing where it is means faster response and lower cleanup costs.

5. Flush your water heater annually. Sediment buildup in water heaters is the #1 cause of early failure. Draining 1-2 gallons from the bottom annually extends the unit's life by years. Cost: free DIY or \$100-150 plumber.

PAGE 4: THE COST-CONTEXT DECISION TREE

When something breaks or needs attention, most homeowners freeze: do I fix this myself? Call someone? How urgent is it?

Here's a framework that cuts through the hesitation.

The \$500 Rule

If a repair costs more than \$500 to fix, get three written estimates before committing. This isn't about being cheap — it's about not leaving money on the table. A single contractor quote gives you their opinion. Three gives you a market view.

This applies to: HVAC repairs, plumbing work, roofing, electrical upgrades, appliance replacement.

Emergency vs. Urgent vs. Routine

Emergency (act now, consequences in hours): - Gas smell or suspected gas leak — leave the house, call the gas company from outside - Sewer backup into the house — don't use any water, call a plumber immediately - Water main break or major pipe burst — shut off main water, call a plumber - Electrical fire or smoking outlet — cut power at the breaker, call the fire department

Urgent (within 24-72 hours): - Furnace not working in heating season — call an HVAC company immediately - Water heater not producing hot water — call a plumber or HVAC company - Broken window or exterior door that won't lock — secure the opening, call a handyman - Active water leak (even small) — water damage compounds fast

Routine (schedule within a few weeks): - Running toilet — fix within a week; wasted water adds up - Slow drain — schedule a drain cleaning - Minor plumbing drip — order the part and fix it; don't let it escalate - HVAC annual maintenance — book in advance for spring/fall

DIY vs. Call a Pro — Quick Reference

Task	DIY?	Cost If Pro
Replace furnace filter	Yes — monthly	N/A
Unclog a drain	Yes, with a snake	\$100-250
Replace a faucet	Yes, with YouTube	\$150-400
Caulk windows/doors	Yes — easy	\$100-300
Replace a light switch	Yes, if comfortable	\$100-200
HVAC annual tune-up	No	\$100-200
Water heater flush	Yes or pro	\$100-150
Gutter cleaning	Yes or pro	\$150-300
Furnace repair	No	\$150-800+
Water heater replacement	No	\$800-2,000
Sewer scope	No	\$150-400
Roof repair	No	\$300-1,500
Foundation concern	No — get an engineer	\$300-600 inspection

PAGE 5: THE MOST EXPENSIVE FIRST-YEAR SURPRISES

New homeowners get hit with bills they didn't see coming. Most of these are preventable with basic maintenance. Here's what to watch for.

HVAC failure: \$150-2,000 An HVAC system that isn't maintained will fail 5-10 years earlier than it should. A \$150 annual tune-up can prevent a \$5,000 replacement. The telltale sign of neglect: a system that's been running for 15+ years without a professional inspection.

Water heater failure: \$800-2,000 A water heater lasts 8-12 years with basic maintenance. Without it, 6-8 years. The signs you need to replace it: rust-colored water, rumbling noises from the tank, water around the base. If your unit is over 10 years old, start budgeting for replacement.

Foundation issues: \$4,000-30,000+ Most foundation problems start small: a crack in the foundation wall, a door that sticks, a floor that isn't level. The cost to fix a hairline crack: \$500-1,000. The cost to fix significant foundation movement: \$15,000-30,000. Every spring and fall, walk your foundation perimeter and look for new cracks.

Sewer line damage: \$3,000-15,000 Tree roots are the most common cause of sewer line damage in homes over 20 years old. Signs: slow drains throughout the house, gurgling toilets, backups when running washing machine. A \$250 sewer scope before you buy (or in your first year) is the best money you can spend.

Ice dam damage: \$1,000-10,000 Ice dams cause ceiling stains, insulation damage, and in severe cases, structural rot. Prevention: clean gutters in fall, add heat cables on problem roof edges, improve attic insulation (\$500-2,000 DIY or pro, but worth it).

Early Detection: What to Look For

Once a quarter, walk your home and look for these warning signs:

- Water stains on ceilings or walls (even small ones)
- Cracks in foundation walls wider than 1/4 inch
- Doors or windows that suddenly stick
- Uneven floors
- Mold or musty odors in basements or crawlspaces
- Rust on water heater or under sinks
- Circuit breakers that trip frequently

Any one of these is worth a professional inspection. Caught early, most of these are \$500 fixes. Caught late, they're \$5,000 emergencies.

PAGE 6: THE HOME MAINTENANCE TRACKING SYSTEM

Most homeowners do a task once and have no idea when they did it last. Then a year passes and they realize they never serviced the furnace, cleaned the gutters, or flushed the water heater.

The fix is a simple system you set up once and use forever.

The Home Notebook

Physical or digital, your choice. This is where you keep:

- **Appliance manuals and warranty info** — store in a binder or Google Drive folder by room
- **Contractor invoices** — photograph every receipt and invoice; cloud storage so you can find it from anywhere
- **Appliance age list** — write down the model number and install date of every major appliance; this tells you when to start budgeting for replacement
- **Maintenance log** — each time you do a task, write the date (例: "Gutters cleaned — Oct 14, 2026")

The Annual Maintenance Calendar

A one-page calendar showing which tasks go in which month. Here's the simplified version:

January: Water heater flush, furnace filter check, smoke detector test **February:** Furnace filter check, ice dam monitoring **March:** Furnace filter check, start planning spring HVAC service **April:** HVAC spring tune-up, roof inspection, gutter clean **May:** Smoke detector test, dryer vent clean, window seal check **June:** Irrigation audit, exterior trim check, garage door service **July:** Smoke detector test, gutter check **August:** Septic/sewer scope (annually), exterior paint check **September:** Smoke detector test, start fall prep planning **October:** Gutter cleanup, furnace priming, weatherstripping check **November:** Pipe winterization, smoke/CO detector test **December:** Furnace filter check, water heater annual flush

The Quarterly Walk-Around

Four times a year (ideally with the seasons), spend 15 minutes walking the exterior:

1. Look at the roof — missing shingles, sagging, moss
2. Check gutters and downspouts — clear, secure, draining away from foundation
3. Walk the foundation perimeter — new cracks, settling, pest entry points
4. Check exterior doors and windows — seals intact, no drafts
5. Look at the grading — soil should slope away from the house, not toward it

Write down what you find. Fix what you can this season. Schedule what you can't.

PAGE 7: BUILDING YOUR PROPERTY PROFILE

The most valuable thing you can do in your first year is document what you own. When you go to sell the house, you'll want this information. When you need to file a warranty claim, you'll need it immediately.

What to Document

Roof: Approximate age, number of layers, last inspection date, any repair history

HVAC: Equipment brand, model number, serial number, install date, service history

Water heater: Type (tank/tankless), brand, model, capacity, install date **Major**

appliances: Refrigerator, stove, dishwasher, washer/dryer — brand, model, purchase

date **Plumbing:** Age of supply lines (copper? galvanized? PEX?), location of main shut-off, location of cleanout **Electrical:** Panel age, amperage, any upgrades done before

your ownership **Exterior:** Deck or patio condition, fence age and condition, driveway/sealing history

Where to Store It

Physical binder near the electrical panel or a cloud folder you can access from your phone. When something breaks, having the model and serial number ready means faster repairs and less back-and-forth with contractors.

PAGE 8: THE FIRST-YEAR PRIORITY CHECKLIST

If you do nothing else in your first year, do these:

Month 1: - ☐ Find and test main water shut-off - ☐ Label every circuit in your electrical panel - ☐ Locate sewer cleanout - ☐ Test all smoke and CO detectors - ☐ Change furnace filter - ☐ Photograph all appliances' model/serial numbers

Month 2: - ☐ Schedule HVAC spring/fall tune-up (book early, contractors book out) - ☐ Get a sewer scope if home is over 20 years old - ☐ Create your home maintenance binder or cloud folder

Season 1 (Spring): - ☐ Roof inspection (walk around exterior) - ☐ Gutter clean - ☐ HVAC tune-up - ☐ Dryer vent clean - ☐ Water heater flush

Season 1 (Fall): - ☐ Gutter cleanup (non-negotiable) - ☐ Furnace inspection - ☐ Weatherstripping and caulking check - ☐ Pipe winterization - ☐ Smoke/CO detector test - ☐ Annual water heater flush

Annually thereafter: - ☐ Follow the seasonal calendar on Page 6 - ☐ Update your property profile each year - ☐ Review and adjust your home maintenance budget

PAGE 9: QUICK-REFERENCE SUMMARY

Seasonal At-a-Glance

Season	Top Tasks
Spring	HVAC tune-up, roof inspection, gutter clean, dryer vent clean
Summer	Irrigation audit, septic/sewer scope, garage door service, exterior check
Fall	Gutter cleanup, furnace prep, weatherstripping, pipe winterization
Winter	Filter changes (monthly), ice dam monitoring, water heater flush

The 5 Non-Negotiable Year-Round Tasks

1. Test smoke and CO detectors monthly
2. Change furnace filters monthly (or as indicated)
3. Know your main water shut-off location
4. Flush water heater annually
5. Keep gutters clear before winter

Cost Quick Reference

Task	DIY Cost	Pro Cost
Furnace filter	\$20-50	N/A
Gutter cleaning	Free	\$150-300
HVAC tune-up	N/A	\$100-200
Furnace inspection	N/A	\$100-200
Water heater flush	Free	\$100-150
Dryer vent clean	Free	\$100-200
Weatherstripping	\$20-40	\$100-300
Sewer scope	N/A	\$150-400
Water heater replacement	N/A	\$800-2,000
HVAC system replacement	N/A	\$5,000-15,000

The \$500 Rule

Get 3 written estimates for any repair over \$500.

Emergency Contacts to Have Ready

- Gas company emergency line
 - Water company emergency line
 - 24-hour plumber
 - 24-hour HVAC service
 - Electrician on call
 - Trusted handyman
-

PAGE 10: NEXT STEPS

You're now equipped. Not with a binder full of things you should do — with a clear system for the things that matter most.

If this guide was helpful, you might also want:

The Home Maintenance Checklist — a printable, room-by-room companion checklist that turns this guide into your go-to reference all year. Available in your Lemon Squeezy library.

New to Lemon Squeezy? Create your free account here and browse the full library:
[LEMON SQUEEZY NEW USER LINK]

Already a member? Access your full library and download the checklist anytime:
[MEMBER'S AREA LINK]

What to Do This Week

Pick one task from the Month 1 checklist on Page 8 and do it this weekend. Just one. The goal isn't to do everything — it's to start building the habit.

Your home will thank you.

This guide is not a substitute for professional advice. When in doubt, consult a licensed contractor.